

LIT QUESTION FOR IHS END-SEM (SPRING 2026)

Both “There Will Come Soft Rains” and “The One Percent War” show us a world in which technology is advanced enough to play a critical role in driving human lives. Pick any one of the two stories to explain the implications of such a development for human beings. (4 marks)

Then, discuss at least two specific literary features (with examples) from that story – such as language, characterization, setting, structure, and narration – that allow us to contemplate such questions. (6 marks)

RUBRIC

4 marks x 1 overarching argument = 4

3 marks x 2 literary strategies = 6

- This is a summary of the basic minimum this answer requires for “There Will Come Soft Rains”:
 - o Technological advancement increasingly insists on inserting technology in key areas/functions that determine and dictate the outcome of human endeavours and even human lives. This abdication of control of information and even decision-making to an inanimate object is dangerous, especially at a time when the object is intelligent and is increasingly beginning to take its own decisions independent of training and other controls that have been built into its architecture.
 - o A highly advanced system runs the house, but while it appears that it serves the humans who had once lived in the house, it also seems that the house regiments and structures their day with an intensity that borders on tyranny. This raises the question of who is serving whom? Who is boss to whom?
 - o A good example here would be the fact that the house appears to decide that the dog is an inconvenience and grudgingly lets it in and does not appear to be feeding it. When the starving dog dies, the robot mice cleaners resent having to come and clean up the remains.
 - o Students will choose two instances from the list of literary strategies and explain them and cite examples from them. Please see slides for both strategies and examples. Ensure that
 - The examples used are actually correct and applicable to the strategy cited.
 - The examples are properly explained and connected to the point the student is trying to make.
- More points for students who do one or more of the following:
 - o The dogged persistence of the house to go on, in spite of the absence of the humans appears to be manic and obsessive and suggests something sinister at work. This raises questions, such as to what extent the house will go in order to ensure its own survival. What does this entail for the world, i.e. will technology run the world, even if there are no humans left, in order to merely survive? What will such a world look like?
 - o Discuss the “prophetic” nature of the poem, which appears to have been realized in the story, and how Bradbury seems to have found it apt enough to include in his dark, post-WWII story, which too seems to warn of the way we

use science and technology to destroy the world and/or to ultimately control and drive humanity. Anyone who writes a reasonable and thoughtful commentary about the warning embedded in the poem and the story and connects that to things happening today.

- o Students may wish to pose reflective questions as a way of understanding/demonstrating their understanding of the nature, purpose, and outcome of technological development, and that's a good way to go about it, but the response has to be rooted firmly in the text and what we can take away from it in a careful reading. Don't reward flights of fancy or speculation that are not connected to the text and its possibilities.

For "The One Percent War":

A basic answer will be able to point out that technology meant to assist in killing the enemy is designed first, to kill. It does not differentiate between the two warring players in war. By design, the technology of war and profit is owned by the powerful few who do not put their lives on the line. Technology here is acting under the control of a powerful few, and outside the control of the soldiers deploying it. In effect, the soldiers are deployed and mined by the suit.

The tech of war also does not/cannot stop. It needs a steady and unending stream of soldiers so that more suits can be used and sold. So that ultimately, human beings service the suit by providing it with soldiers.

The answer should be able to point to the structure of the story – each page reads like an episode with a specific scene of place, time, event and narration. Qualities of language like sentence length, vocabulary, punctuation, and repetition should be pointed out with specific and accurate examples. The third person narration creates a world that is everywhere and nowhere, and in an unspecified time.

More points to students who can move beyond explaining what technology is doing in the story, and ask reflective questions about the nature and purpose of technological development. This should be possible to do in a story like "The One Percent War" where technology has no other purpose than to kill, and perpetuate war. The overriding similarity between the description of the world of the story, and the world of a generic war based video game sets the tone of the story.